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PM Modi's Europe Visit Begins in Nice, with Tech and Bilateral Relations in Focus

PM Modi's Europe visit begins in Nice, with tech, bilateral relations in focus

Sriram Lakshman

LONDON

Prime Minister Narendra Modi arrived in Nice on Saturday evening, the first stop on his six-day tour of France and Slovakia. The Prime Minister's visit to the French Riviera revolves around a tech summit, **Bharat Innovates 2026**, on Sunday, which he will inaugurate with French President Emmanuel Macron.

The tech event, as per the government, is aimed at bringing together deep-tech ventures and higher education institutes from India, among others, to explore cooperation in research and co-development, investment and technology transfer.

Following the event, Mr. Modi and Mr. Macron will lead bilateral discussions between the two sides which are expected to cover a broad range of subjects including defence, tech, regional and global issues.

It is expected that the U.S. and Israel conflict with Iran will be discussed between the sides, with U.S. President Donald Trump saying a settlement was due to be signed on Sunday.

India and France had formally elevated their partnership to a 'Special Global Strategic Partnership' in February this year and announced that 2026 was the India-France Year of Innovation.



Narendra Modi

Mr. Modi will travel to Slovakia on Sunday evening and return to France for the G7 Summit in the alpine resort of Évian-les-Bains. India has been invited as an outreach partner, along with other countries. At Évian, there is a possibility of a bilateral meeting with Mr. Trump. Following the G7 Summit, Mr. Modi

will arrive in Paris for another tech focused event, VivaTech on June 18. India is the AI Country Partner for the event which is held annually.

The PM's arrival in France was foreshadowed by rising tensions between India and the United States after an attack by U.S. forces killed three Indian seafarers off the coast of Oman.

"In addition to Nice, this France visit includes programmes in Evian and Paris. There will be bilateral and multilateral meetings, which will be aimed at improving India's friendship with key development partners," Mr. Modi wrote on X, shortly after landing in France.

PM Modi's Europe Visit Begins in Nice, with Tech and Bilateral Relations in Focus

Context

PM Narendra Modi arrived in Nice, France, first stop of his six-day tour of France and Slovakia. His visit revolves around the tech summit **Bharat Innovates 2026**, inaugurated with French President Emmanuel Macron.

India and France formally elevated ties to a 'Special Global Strategic Partnership' in February 2026; 2026 declared the India-France Year of Innovation.

Modi also attended the G7 Summit at Évian-les-Bains as an outreach partner and visited Paris for **VivaTech (June 18) : India is the AI Country Partner.**

India-France Strategic Partnership

Special Global Strategic Partnership (elevated February 2026) : covers defence, tech, space, nuclear energy, and culture.

Key areas of discussion: defence cooperation, technology transfer, research and co-development, regional and global issues.

France is one of India's key suppliers of defence equipment : Rafale jets, Scorpène submarines.

US-Israel conflict with Iran was also on the bilateral agenda.

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Horizon 2047 Agreement: Horizon 2047 agreement between **India and France** lays down the future roadmap of India-France collaboration for the next 25 years. The collaboration between India and France in emerging domains such as supercomputing, cloud computing, artificial intelligence, and quantum technologies holds significant importance for India's future.

VivaTech 2026 : Paris

Annual technology conference held in Paris; India is the AI Country Partner for 2026.

Focus: Deep-tech ventures, higher education collaboration, investment and technology transfer between India and France.

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G7 Summit : Évian-les-Bains

India invited as an outreach partner (not a G7 member) reflects India's growing global stature.

G7 members: USA, UK, France, Germany, Italy, Japan, Canada + EU (non-enumerated member)

India has been a regular invitee at G7 outreach sessions under the current geopolitical climate.

Possibility of a bilateral meeting with US President Donald Trump at Évian was highlighted.

It is organized around shared values of pluralism, liberal democracy, and representative government. G7 members are major IMF advanced economies.

Russia having been a formal member (as part of the G8) from 1997 until its expulsion in 2014.

The G7 is not based on a treaty and has no permanent secretariat or office. It is organized through a presidency that rotates annually among the member states, with the presiding state setting the group's priorities and hosting the summit;

G7 countries make up **10% of the world's population** and **31% of global GDP**.

All G7 members are members of G20.

Most G7 countries have a high level of gross debt, especially Japan (263% of GDP), Italy (151%) and the US (133%).

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The groundwork for the summit, including matters to be discussed and follow-up meetings, is done by the “**sherpas**” (representatives of members).

It ends with the release of a non-binding communique summarising key political commitments.

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G20

Founded in 1999 after the Asian financial crisis

Initially started off as a meeting of finance ministers and central bank governors.

As a response to the financial crisis of 2008, the G-20 was upgraded to head of state level in an inaugural summit in Washington, D.C.

It is also known as the “Summit on Financial Markets and the World Economy” and represents 80% of the global GDP.

G-20 operates without a permanent secretariat or staff

Groups chair rotates annually among member countries

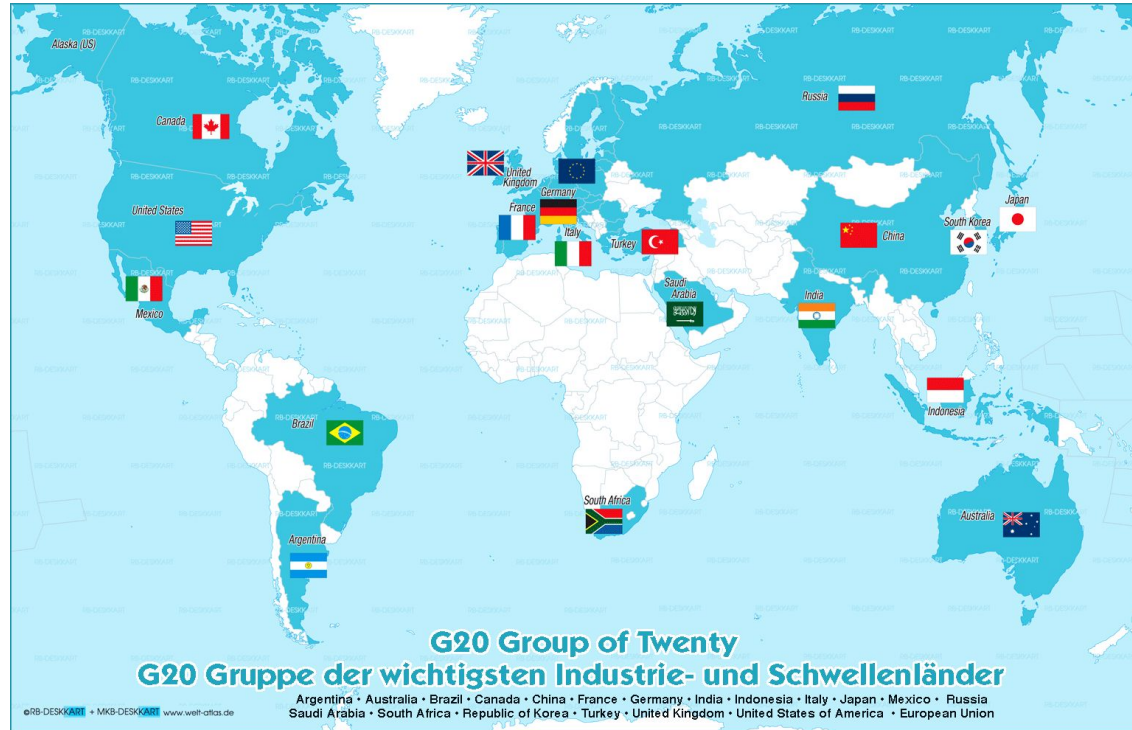
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Troika: The G20 does not have a charter or a secretariat. The Presidency is supported by the Troika, which includes the previous, current, and incoming presidencies. The G20 Presidency hosts the Summit and directs the G20 agenda for a calendar year.

A non-binding forum: Its decisions are **not legally binding**, and member countries are not required to implement them.

Working with international organisations: The G20 members also work closely with international organisations such as the International Monetary Fund (IMF), the World Bank, and the World Trade Organization (WTO).

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Question 1: Consider the following statements about G-20:

1. The G-20 group was originally established as a platform for the Finance Ministers and Central Bank Governors to discuss international economic and financial issues.
2. Digital public infrastructure is one of India's G-20 priorities.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct? **(UPSC Prelims 2023)**

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

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Question 3: In which one of the following groups are all the four countries members of G20?
(UPSC Prelims 2020)

- (a) Argentina, Mexico, South Africa and Turkey
- (b) Australia, Canada, Malaysia and New Zealand
- (c) Brazil, Iran, Saudi Arabia and Vietnam
- (d) Indonesia, Japan, Singapore and South Korea

Practice Questions

Q. With reference to India-France relations, consider the following statements:

- 1. India and France elevated their partnership to a 'Special Global Strategic Partnership' in 2026.**
- 2. India is a full member of the G7 grouping.**
- 3. The Rafale fighter jets and Scorpène-class submarines are examples of India-France defence cooperation.**

Which of the above statements is/are correct?

- (a) 1 and 3 only**
- (b) 2 and 3 only**
- (c) 1 only**
- (d) 1, 2 and 3**

Answer : (a) 1 and 3 only

Statement 2 is incorrect — India is NOT a member of the G7. It is invited as an outreach partner. G7 members are USA, UK, France, Germany, Italy, Japan, and Canada (plus the EU). Statements 1 and 3 are correct.

Where to apply for UPSC Exam

- **Prelims** : India-France Strategic Partnership; G7 members and India's role as outreach partner; Bharat Innovates 2026; VivaTech
- **Mains** : Critically examine India's strategic partnership with France and its significance for India's foreign policy. / India's growing engagement with the G7 : opportunities and limitations.
- **Interview** : What is the significance of PM Modi's Europe visit for India's foreign policy? / Should India seek full G7 membership?

Meet the Frogs that Build 'Cloudy' Nests in South Africa's Trees

Meet the frogs that build 'cloudy' nests in South Africa's trees

D.P. Kasbekar

For most frogs, life begins as a game of odds. They lay their eggs in the water, where fish and insects gobble up about 98% of them before they even have a chance to hatch. The African grey foam-nest tree frog (*Chiromantis xerampelina*) figured a way out: it took its nest into the air.

In the rainy season between October and February, a female frog finds a

branch overhanging a pool and begins secreting a special fluid. As the male and the female mate, the pair uses their hind legs like whisks to churn the secretions into a thick, bubbly froth. The result is a foamy nest.

A few days later, the eggs hatch inside this nest. When the tadpoles are ready, they simply break through the bottom of the foam and drop into the pool below, beginning the

next stage of their lives.

While a single pair of frogs can build a nest, these frogs prefer a 'foam party' approach. Researchers from three Australian universities recently studied these frogs in South Africa and found that when it comes to nesting, there is real strength in numbers.

The findings were published in the journal *Evolution* on June 2.

Sometimes, a single fe-

male is joined by a dozen or more males. This results in a better home rather than chaos.

More males meant more legs churning, leading to nests up to three times larger than those built by a single pair.

While smaller nests dry out quickly, killing the eggs inside, larger nests hold onto moisture for longer, ensuring more tadpoles survive from the nest.

You might wonder: why

would a male frog help build a nest if he is competing with 12 other frogs? Using DNA testing, the researchers found that in these crowded nests, paternity is often split. By cooperating to build a large, moist fortress, the males ensure at least some of their offspring survive, rather than losing all of them to a dried-out nest.

The scientists also suspected that the males' skin and fluids contain surfac-

tants – compounds similar to laundry detergent – that keep the bubbles from popping.

The African grey foam-nest tree frog reminds us that survival is not always about being the strongest or the fastest. Sometimes, it is about having the best teammates, the best chemistry, and the most impressive bubble-making skills in the forest.

(D.P. Kasbekar is a retired scientist)

Meet the Frogs that Build 'Cloudy' Nests in South Africa's Trees

The African Grey Foam-Nest Tree Frog

Scientific name: *Chiromantis xerampelina* found in South Africa.

Unique nesting behaviour: builds foam nests on tree branches overhanging pools.

During the rainy season (October–February), a female finds a branch and secretes a special fluid; the pair uses hind legs like whisks to churn it into thick, bubbly froth a foam nest.

Eggs hatch inside the nest; tadpoles break through the bottom and drop into the pool below.

Strength in Numbers : Cooperative Nesting

These frogs prefer a 'foam party' approach where a single female may be joined by a dozen or more males.

More males = more legs churning = nests up to three times larger than those built by a single pair.

Larger nests retain moisture for longer, ensuring more tadpoles survive.

Smaller nests dry out quickly, killing the eggs inside.

Meet the Frogs that Build 'Cloudy' Nests in South Africa's Trees

Ecological and Evolutionary Significance

Demonstrates cooperative behaviour (altruism) in amphibians despite reproductive competition.

Survival strategy: cooperation over competition when individual effort leads to total failure (nest drying out).

Relevant to: Evolutionary biology, animal behaviour, ecology, and biodiversity conservation.

Where to apply for UPSC Exam

Which of the following organisms perform waggle dance for others of their kin to indicate the direction and the distance to a source of their food?

This question was previously asked in

UPSC Civil Services Prelims
2023: General Studies (SET - ...

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1. Butterflies

2. Dragonflies

3. Honeybees

4. Wasps

Where to apply for UPSC Exam

Which one of the following makes a tool with a stick to scrape insects from a hole in a tree or a log of wood?

1. Fishing cat

2. Orangutan

3. Otter

4. Sloth bear

Assam-Nagaland Pact Raises Hopes of Higher Oil & Gas Output from Northeast

Why an Assam-Nagaland pact raises hopes of higher oil & gas output from Northeast

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, June 13

THE UNION government, Assam and Nagaland Thursday signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) that paves the way for the resumption of oil and gas exploration along the resource-rich and contested boundary of the two states after three decades.

The Northeast is considered the birthplace of India's oil and gas industry and Assam is among India's major oil and gas producing states.

This agreement is part of that effort, and comes at a time when the country is grappling with high prices of imported oil and gas, as well as supply constraints, owing to the effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz amid the West Asia war.

The government has implemented several policy reforms to encourage investments in India's oil and gas exploration and production sector.

Resumption of oil, gas exploration in contested border

Although these "upstream" activities have long gestation periods, the agreement could augment the country's domestic oil and gas production in the medium to long term. According to officials aware of

the matter, the MoU specifically targets the disputed area belt, or DAB, along the Assam-Nagaland border. With the MoU in place, oil and gas exploration and production are expected to gather pace across more than 1,000 sq km along the Assam-Nagaland border.

Oil, gas, and mineral exploration activities have remained suspended in the DAB for three decades owing to law and order issues amid boundary disputes between the two states.

The DAB is expected to contain promising hydrocarbon prospects. According to the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), the MoU establishes a coordinated framework for facilitating mineral oil operations in the area, ensuring operational continuity, safety and security of personnel and assets, and effective coordination among all stakeholders.

The framework is expected to support exploration and production activities, encourage investment in the upstream petroleum sector and contribute towards the country's energy security objectives, it said.

The MHA said that both states decided that they would not allow any obstacle to India's oil exploration, and would advance on the path of mutual cooperation, as these resources constitute national wealth.

According to the MHA re-



Oil, gas, and mineral exploration activities have remained suspended in the contested area for three decades now. REUTERS

lease, apart from six designated oil and gas fields, the Nagaland government has agreed to oil exploration across Nagaland.

"He (Home Minister Amit Shah) stated that the Government of Assam is also in agreement, as this is a win-win situation for all stakeholders. The Home Minister said that this tripartite agreement will pave the way for mineral exploration and mining across the entire North-East region," the release said.

Govt sees significant oil, gas potential in region

"Since Assam alone accounts for nearly 22% of India's crude oil reserves and around 15% of the country's natural gas

reserves, while Nagaland possesses significant hydrocarbon potential in the Naga-Schuppen Belt of the Assam-Arakan Basin, resources where hydrocarbons flow naturally and those which have huge un-

E.

tapped resources, the outlook for E&P [exploration and production] activities in the North East is therefore extremely promising."

Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri posted on social media platform X, adding that the MoU paves the way for Nagaland to produce oil and gas after 31 years. According to the MHA release, Shah said that the MoU could potentially help increase oil production capacity from the Northeast from the current capacity of 1,000-1,500 barrels per day by more than

tenfold, adding that the region also possesses "and immense wealth of minerals". While it is difficult to predict exactly how soon this tripartite agreement would start bearing fruit, Shah emphasised that in due course, it will bring significant relief to India and enhance the country's self-reliance.

"Union Home Minister Shri Amit Shah expressed confidence that the extraction of oil and gas resources available in Nagaland would significantly reduce India's dependence on foreign sources in this sector. He said that, in the absence of such an agreement and due to certain longstanding challenges, the economic development of both states had remained affected for a considerable period.

"However, he noted that the agreement signed today will open a major pathway for the economic development of both Assam and Nagaland," the MHA release said.

"By creating a framework for cooperation between the governments, this MoU signed in the presence of HM Sh @AmitShah Ji, provides certainty to investors, facilitates operational continuity, enables regulatory coordination and creates conditions necessary for long-term investment decisions," Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri said.

Assam-Nagaland Pact Raises Hopes of Higher Oil & Gas Output from Northeast

Context

Union Government, Assam and Nagaland signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) on June 13, 2026.

The MoU paves the way for resumption of oil and gas exploration along the contested Assam-Nagaland border suspended for three decades.

Signed in the presence of Union Home Minister Amit Shah.

Context: India grappling with high imported oil prices and supply disruptions due to the effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz amid the West Asia war.

Disputed Area Belt (DAB)

The MoU specifically targets the Disputed Area Belt (DAB) along the Assam-Nagaland border.

Oil, gas, and mineral exploration had been suspended in the DAB for three decades due to law and order issues and boundary disputes.

The DAB is expected to contain promising hydrocarbon prospects.

The MoU covers more than 1,000 sq km along the Assam-Nagaland border.

Assam-Nagaland Pact Raises Hopes of Higher Oil & Gas Output from Northeast

Significance of Northeast's Oil & Gas Potential

The Northeast is considered the birthplace of India's oil and gas industry, Assam is one of India's major oil and gas producing states.

Assam alone accounts for nearly 22% of India's crude oil reserves and around 15% of natural gas reserves.

Nagaland possesses significant hydrocarbon potential in the Naga-Schuppen Belt of the Assam-Arakan Basin.

The MoU could increase oil production capacity from the Northeast from the current 1,000–1,500 barrels/day by more than tenfold.

Assam-Arakan Basin and Naga-Schuppen Belt

Assam-Arakan Basin: One of India's oldest and most significant sedimentary basins for hydrocarbon exploration.

Naga-Schuppen Belt: A fold-and-thrust belt where hydrocarbons flow naturally and huge untapped resources exist.

The region also possesses immense wealth of minerals, not just hydrocarbons.

Practice Questions

Q. Consider the following statements with reference to India's oil and gas sector in the Northeast:

- 1. Assam accounts for nearly 22% of India's crude oil reserves and about 15% of its natural gas reserves.**
- 2. The Naga-Schuppen Belt is part of the Assam-Arakan Basin, known for significant hydrocarbon potential.**
- 3. The Disputed Area Belt (DAB) along the Assam-Meghalaya border has been actively explored for oil and gas in the past decade.**

Which of the above statements is/are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only**
- (b) 2 and 3 only**
- (c) 1 only**
- (d) 1, 2 and 3**

Answer : (a) 1 and 2 only

Statements 1 and 2 are correct as per the article.

Statement 3 is incorrect : the DAB has NOT been actively explored. Oil, gas, and mineral exploration activities have remained SUSPENDED in the DAB for three decades due to law and order issues and the Assam-Nagaland boundary dispute. The 2026 MoU aims to resume this exploration.

Thank you